

What happens if your next leaders are already on the team, but no one is looking at them?

Our internal bench was thin, and the external talent we hired wasn't staying.

- Career Progression
- People Leadership
- Learning and Capability Expertise

We were told to look outside.

Senior leadership wanted “new blood, new ideas, no recycling,” so open leadership roles were increasingly filled with external talent. But they weren't staying. The reality of fast-paced retail — demanding customers, high expectations, and leading young teams — often wasn't what they expected when they took the job.



I started noticing who we weren't talking about.

As a new HR Business Partner, I was close to hiring, talent development, benefits, and employee relations — including the performance conversations that moved people up or out.

I heard plenty about the top performers. I heard plenty about the bottom performers. But I wasn't hearing much about everyone in the middle. What if some of our future leaders were already there — quietly getting the job done without anyone asking what they wanted next?

Most of my work happened through leaders.

I'd ask “Tell me about your staff. Let's go one by one.” Sometimes we'd get to a name and the leader couldn't tell me much about them. That became the coaching moment:

“You can't develop someone you haven't bothered to know.”



People started feeling noticed.

Once leaders expanded their focus, skip-level conversations became more positive. People felt seen, and more optimistic about their future.



And the bench got deeper.

When leaders knew their people - not just top and bottom performers - internal promotions increased 15%.

And those new leaders stayed.

AT A GLANCE



27 stores supported



450 employees



5 months into role



15% increase internal promotions

WHY THIS STORY

This is one of the earliest examples of the leader I was becoming. I was still learning where my role began and ended, but I was already asking questions about who gets seen, who gets heard, and what happens when leaders look beyond the obvious choices.

This story also demonstrates:

Talent strategy

Employee advocacy

Coaching leaders

Succession planning

Organizational awareness

IF WE TALK, ASK ME ABOUT

- The employee I found because nobody was talking about them.
- The manager reaction when they realized they didn't know their teams.
- What I learned from people who didn't want promotions.
- How I handled people who wanted leadership, but weren't ready yet.
- When I learned to stop solving problems for employees.

WHAT I'M PROUD OF

I moved into HR because I knew the stores and wanted the people working in them to have an advocate. Making overlooked employees visible — and seeing more of them get opportunities — was exactly why I wanted the role.

MY GUIDING PRINCIPLE

Your best salesperson isn't automatically your best leader. Leadership potential shows up differently: in how someone influences others, takes ownership, makes things better, and whether they actually want to lead.

IF I HAD A DO-OVER

I'd recognize sooner that being able to solve the problem didn't mean I should. Sometimes the better answer was developing the leader who owned it.